

**COMMUNITY PERCEPTIONS OF CRIMINOLOGY STUDENTS
AS FUTURE POLICE OFFICERS**

Bachelor of Science in Criminology

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Chapter 1

INTRODUCTION

Background of the Study

A common image of criminology in everyday community life is its close association with police work. When people hear that a student is taking Bachelor of Science in Criminology, they may immediately assume that the student intends to become a police officer after graduation. This association is understandable because policing is highly visible and remains one of the career areas commonly connected with criminology. However, the assumption can become too narrow when criminology is treated as if becoming a police officer were the automatic or only career destination of every criminology student.

The concern is important because perceptions can influence how a profession is understood. A community member may form expectations about a criminology student based on the belief that the student will eventually become a police officer, even when the student may have different plans or interests. The perception may also affect how the community interprets the identity, goals, and possible future role of a criminology student. For the present study, the issue is therefore not whether criminology students are prepared to become police officers, but how community members understand the connection between studying criminology and becoming a police officer.

This issue is also relevant because criminology has a wider professional scope. Republic Act No. 11131, or the Philippine Criminology Profession Act of

2018, recognizes professional activities in law enforcement administration and investigation, teaching, forensic and scientific crime detection, correctional and rehabilitation work, research and consultancy, and private investigation and security. The law also identifies criminology-related positions in forensic, correctional, investigative, security, fire, jail, probation, parole, and other criminal-justice-related areas. Thus, criminology is broader than police service alone (Republic Act No. 11131, 2018).

Existing studies further indicate that criminology students may have career interests involving several agencies and fields. Aroy et al. (2024) found that criminology students at the University of Mindanao considered the Philippine National Police, Bureau of Fire Protection, and Bureau of Jail Management and Penology among their preferred agencies. Nobis (2025) examined motivations, opportunities, and challenges affecting career decisions among first-year criminology students, while Asoy and Brosas (2025) emphasized the need to make the wider career opportunities available to criminology graduates more visible. These studies are important because they show that criminology is related to multiple career possibilities rather than to one occupation only.

The need for the present study becomes clearer when the issue is viewed from the community's perspective. Existing literature has examined students' career preferences and public perceptions of police and public safety, but less attention has been given to how ordinary adult community members themselves understand criminology students and why they associate the course with becoming police officers. The present study therefore seeks to explore this

perception among adults in selected communities in Calasiao, Pangasinan, identify influences that shape the perception, and examine whether participants recognize the broader career scope of criminology.

In the Philippines, the association between criminology and police service is particularly visible because police work is one of the most recognizable criminal-justice careers associated with the course. Aroy et al. (2024) found that the Philippine National Police was among the preferred agencies of criminology students in their study, alongside the Bureau of Fire Protection and the Bureau of Jail Management and Penology. These findings help explain why the public may commonly connect criminology with government law-enforcement or public-safety agencies, while also showing that students consider multiple possible destinations.

Philippine educational materials likewise present criminology as a broad field. Tarlac State University's Bachelor of Science in Criminology program identifies opportunities in criminological research, scientific crime detection and investigation, crime prevention, law enforcement, correctional administration, public safety, security management, criminalistics, and academe. This institutional presentation reinforces the view that criminology graduates may work in a range of professional fields rather than automatically becoming police officers.

Asoy and Brosas (2025) examined ways to increase career opportunities for criminology graduates and highlighted opportunities in law enforcement,

public safety, security, government offices, and the private sector. The study emphasizes the importance of exposing students and stakeholders to career possibilities that may be less visible than traditional police employment. This is directly relevant to the present study because a narrow public understanding may persist when the wider professional scope is not widely recognized.

Nobis (2025) also examined career paths among first-year criminology students and emphasized motivations, opportunities, and challenges in criminal-justice careers. Other recent Philippine studies have similarly examined family, peer, personal, socioeconomic, and institutional influences in criminology students' career aspirations. These findings suggest that career expectations are shaped by several forces and should not be reduced to the mere fact of taking a criminology program.

Despite these studies, limited attention has been given to how adult community members themselves understand criminology students and why they immediately connect the course to future police service. This gap is important in the Philippine setting because the public's understanding of the criminology profession may influence common assumptions about students, their goals, and their future careers.

Calasiao, Pangasinan provides an appropriate local setting for examining community perceptions of criminology students because the study seeks to understand how the belief about criminology and police work appears within actual community environments. The present study will involve selected barangay communities in Calasiao, Pangasinan rather than treating the

municipality selected adult community members share one identical viewpoint. Different community settings may expose residents to different social experiences, community activities, law-enforcement visibility, and sources of information.

Tanudra, Tañega, and Las (2017) examined public perception of the quality of police officers' response to crime incidents among residents of selected barangays in Davao City. Their study shows that community members' perceptions can be examined in relation to police work and public safety. However, the present study focuses more specifically on how adult community members understand criminology students and why they associate the course with becoming police officers. The present study responds to this gap by listening to community members' own explanations rather than assuming in advance that the perception is either correct or incorrect. The study will also explore whether participants recognize alternative career paths within the broader scope of criminology.

The local setting is also appropriate because the study does not seek to measure a numerical prevalence of the perception among all residents of Calasiao. Instead, it seeks detailed qualitative descriptions from the perceptions of the adult participants. By examining selected communities, the researchers can identify recurring themes and patterns while keeping the study geographically focused and manageable.

This study therefore addresses a specific local concern: the possibility that community members equate taking criminology with becoming a police officer.

Understanding the reasons behind this perception and the extent to which community members recognize other criminology-related careers may contribute to better public understanding of the profession and provide useful information for criminology students and educators.

STATEMENT OF THE PROBLEM

This study seeks to understand how adult community members from selected communities in Calasiao, Pangasinan perceive criminology students as future police officers. Specifically, it seeks to answer the following questions:

1. How do adult community members from selected communities in Calasiao, Pangasinan describe their perception of criminology students as future police officers?
2. What factors do adult community members identify as influencing their perception of criminology students as future police officers?
3. How do adult community members describe their understanding of the broader scope of the criminology profession and its alternative career paths under Republic Act No. 11131?

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE STUDY

This study will be significant for the following:

Criminology Students. The findings may help criminology students understand how community members view their course and future professional identity. The study may also help students recognize common assumptions about criminology

and communicate that the profession includes career areas beyond traditional police work.

Criminology Educators and Institutions. The findings may provide useful information for educators and criminology programs when explaining the professional scope of criminology and presenting career pathways that may be less visible to the public. The findings may also support community-oriented activities that improve understanding of the profession.

Community Members. The study may increase awareness of the different professional roles that criminology graduates may pursue. A clearer understanding of the profession may help community members form more informed views about criminology students and avoid automatically equating the course with police service.

Future Researchers. The study may serve as a local reference for researchers who wish to examine public perception, professional stereotypes, criminology education, career awareness, police-centered perceptions, or related community-based concerns in other locations.

SCOPE AND LIMITATIONS OF THE STUDY

The study will gather participants' views through a researcher-developed semi-structured interview guide. The interview questions will be based directly on the Statement of the Problem and checked against each research question to ensure that every question is relevant to the objectives of the study. The guide

will be reviewed by the research adviser before data collection. The study will interpret recurring ideas and themes from the interview responses.

The study will be limited to selected barangay communities in Calasiao, Pangasinan identified and approved by the researchers and research adviser. Only participants who are 18 years old and above, residents of the selected communities, willing to participate, and able to provide informed responses will be included. The study will not determine the actual career intentions of criminology students, evaluate the performance or competence of police officers, or establish statistically how common the perception is among selected adult community members of Calasiao. Because the study is qualitative and uses purposive sampling, findings will represent the experiences and viewpoints of the selected participants and will not be statistically generalized to all residents or all communities.

DEFINITION OF TERMS

Criminology Students. Refer to students enrolled in a Bachelor of Science in Criminology program who are discussed by participants in relation to assumptions or expectations about future careers.

Future Police Officers. Refer to the police-service role that participants associate with criminology students when they assume that students taking criminology will eventually enter police service.

Adult Community Members. Refer to residents aged 18 years and above from the selected barangay communities in Calasiao, Pangasinan who meet the inclusion criteria and participate in the study.

Factors. Refer to the influences that participants identify as shaping their perception of criminology students as future police officers, including social, environmental, media or informational, psychological or experiential, and institutional influences.

Alternative Career Paths. Refer to criminology-related career opportunities other than becoming a police officer that are identified by participants and consistent with broader professional scope under RA 11131.

Selected Communities. Refers to the communities within Calasiao, Pangasinan that will be identified and approved by the researchers and research adviser as the study sites.

Republic Act No. 11131. Refers to the Philippine Criminology Profession Act of 2018, which provides the legal framework for the practice, education, registration, and professional development of criminology in the Philippines.

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